The Synergistic Impact of Full-Day PreK, Parent Involvement, and Outreach Staff on Reducing Chronic Absenteeism in the Child-Parent Centers

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Historical and Current Context

Child-Parent Center (CPC) program

Early childhood intervention from preschool through 3rd grade, targeting low-income children and their families.

- Over 30 years of research has demonstrated returns of $8 per dollar spent.
- The CPC produces cognitive, socio-emotional, mental health, and economic gains throughout the life course (Reynolds et al., 2011).

Midwest Child-Parent Center Expansion Project

Targeted school reform effort across the Midwest.

- Provides intensive and continuous educational and family-support services
- Pre-K to 3rd grade
- Assesses validity of program in a broader array of social contexts.
- **Core Program Elements:**
  - Effective Learning Experiences, PreK-3rd
  - Aligned curriculum
  - Parent involvement and engagement
  - Collaborative Leadership Team
  - Continuity and Stability
  - Professional development system

Research Question

Overall goal is to assess the impact of the Midwest CPC Expansion project by child, family, and program characteristics. Specifically,

1. What impact do full-day PreK, parent involvement, and outreach staff have on chronic absence as individual factors?
2. To what extent is there a benefit from having more than one of these factors present in a child's school?

Sample

Element	Yes	No	Total
Full-day prek	409	1315	1724
Full-time SCR	897	827	1724
High PI	523	1201	1724
At least two	404	1320	1724
All three	70	1654	1724



Methodology

- **Intervention group sample**: Any student who entered a CPC site by January 2013 AND received at least 4 months of instruction at the site.
- **Average Attendance:** The average monthly attendance for a CPC student for all of the months the student was in the program.
- **Chronic Absence:** Dummy coded variable indicating whether or not a student missed 10% or more of all class days for the time the student was in a CPC Center.
- **High Parent Involvement:** Parent Resource Teacher rating of school level parent involvement. If 30% or more of the school met the 2.5 hour per week requirement, this was coded as high parent involvement.

Adjusted Means

		Average Attendance	Chronic Absence
Full-Day	YES	86%***	53%***
	NO	83%***	65%***
SCR	YES	86%***	57%***
	NO	82%***	68%***
High PI	YES	82%***	64%***
	NO	85%***	61%***
At least two	YES	83%***	58%***
	NO	84%***	63%***
All 3	YES	90%***	39%***
	NO	84%***	63%***

Means were adjusted using regression models controlling for age, gender, race, free lunch status and school size. Standard errors were clustered at the school level.

Results

- The following three key components were found to be effective for **increasing daily attendance rates** and **decreasing chronic absence rates** in Chicago preschool students:
  - Full-day PreK,
  - a Full-time School-Community Representative,
  - High parent involvement
- The presence of all three elements indicates a positive, synergistic impact on attendance.
  - Students with ***none of the three elements*** in place (369 students)
    - 75% were chronically absent, or missed 10 or more days during the year and had an average attendance rate of 80%.
  - Students with ***all three elements***.
    - 39% were chronically absent during the same year and had an average attendance rate of 90%.

Policy Implications

School districts should:

1. **Increase access to full-day PreK** to increase attendance and reduce the rate of chronic absenteeism
2. **Increase emphasis on school-home connections** to increase parent involvement in school and at home.
   - Hire parent involvement staff
   - Parent involvement staff should work out in the community to connect with hard to reach families.

The **maximum reduction in chronic absenteeism** can be achieved when all of the above elements are instituted at the school-level.

Future Directions

- Continue investigation into attendance, absenteeism, and interventions across other project districts to see if results are similar.
- Analyze data controlling for individual student level characteristics.
- Examine the relationship between PreK chronic absenteeism and attendance and Kindergarten readiness as well as PreK attendance to attendance in later grades.

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